A Comprehensive Appeal

He could have commanded. For love’s sake he appealed — and offered to pay the debt.

Where this study fits

The Epistle to Philemon · three studies · this study highlighted

01 Philemon 1–7

A Cautious Approach

Greetings · Grace and Peace · Gratitude · Gladness

02 Philemon 8–19

A Comprehensive Appeal

Necessity · Responsibility · Liability

03 Philemon 20–25

A Compelling Appendix

A Personal Word · A Public Word · A Parting Word

Study 2 is the heart of the letter: three lines of argument for receiving Onesimus as a brother.

Paul had his moments

Introduction · Proverbs 18:24 · Acts 15:36

The split
Acts 15:36–39

- Paul and Barnabas plan to revisit the churches
- Barnabas wants his cousin John Mark
- Mark had left in the middle of the work
- They part company

Reconciled to Mark
Colossians 4:10

- “If he comes to you, welcome him”

Reconciled to Barnabas
1 Corinthians 9:6

- Paul puts himself with Barnabas: “only Barnabas and I”

“A man who would have friends must himself be friendly.” Friends don’t come by osmosis.

Three lines of argument

Philemon 8–19 · the commentary's outline

v.8	**I.A Necessity — Paul gives his rights**	*παρρησία · ἐπιτάσσω*
vv.9–13	**I.B Necessity — Paul gives up his rights: higher ground, gains, goals**	*παρακαλῶ · ἄχρηστος / εὔχρηστος*
v.14	**II.A Responsibility — legal restoration**	*ἀνάγκη*
v.15	**II.B Responsibility of Onesimus — life redemption**	
vv.16–17	**II.C Responsibility of Philemon — love relationship**	*ἀδελφὸς ἀγαπητός · κοινωνός*
vv.18–19	**III. Liability — owed to Philemon; owed by Philemon**	*ἐλλογάω · ἀποτίνω*

Paul gives up his rights

Philemon 9–13 · Commentary I.B

Higher ground
v. 9

- “For love’s sake I rather appeal”
- Paul the aged — 57 by the sermon’s estimate
- A prisoner of Jesus, not of Rome or the Jews

Higher gains
vv. 10–11

- Paul gained a new son, begotten in chains
- Philemon gains a new slave — with interest
- Pun: unprofitable → profitable

Higher goals
vv. 12–13

- Philemon: receive him or not — “my own heart”
- Paul: keep him or not — he chose to forgo it

It’s a lot better to ask somebody to do things from this level than to force them from this level.

Negative, positive, superlative

Philemon 16–17 · Commentary II.C

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No longer a slave

Legally he may still be property — but human laws are not the ultimate law

v. 16a

+

More than a slave

A beloved brother, in the flesh and in the Lord

v. 16b

++

As you would me

“If then you count me as a partner, receive him as you would me”

v. 17

You wouldn’t put Paul in chains. Don’t put him in chains.

The ledger: debit and credit

Philemon 18–19 · Commentary III

Debit side

owed to Philemon · vv. 18–19a

- “Put that on my account” (ἐλλόγα)
- Whatever he stole — Paul will pay
- Whatever time he was away — Paul will pay
- “I, Paul, am writing with my own hand”

The picture

imputation

- We owed a debt we could not pay
- Christ: “Put it on My account” — for the whole world
- 2 Cor. 5:21; Heb. 10:7 — willingly

Credit side

owed by Philemon · v. 19b

- “Not to mention … you owe me even your own self”
- The iron fist — in a velvet glove

“I owed a debt I could not pay; He paid a debt He did not owe.”

Discuss and apply

Philemon 8–19 · from the study's questions and applications

Discuss

1. Where are you tempted to use your rights instead of making an appeal for love's sake?
2. Who is the "Onesimus" in your life?
3. How is v. 18 a picture of what Christ did for us?

Apply

Show Yourself Friendly

Speak first to two people you don't usually talk to.

Appeal, Don't Command

Turn one demand into a request with good reasons.

Put It on My Account

Cancel one debt you are holding against someone.

In one line: Let's be a friendly person — then a friendly church — more like the Friend we have in Jesus.